

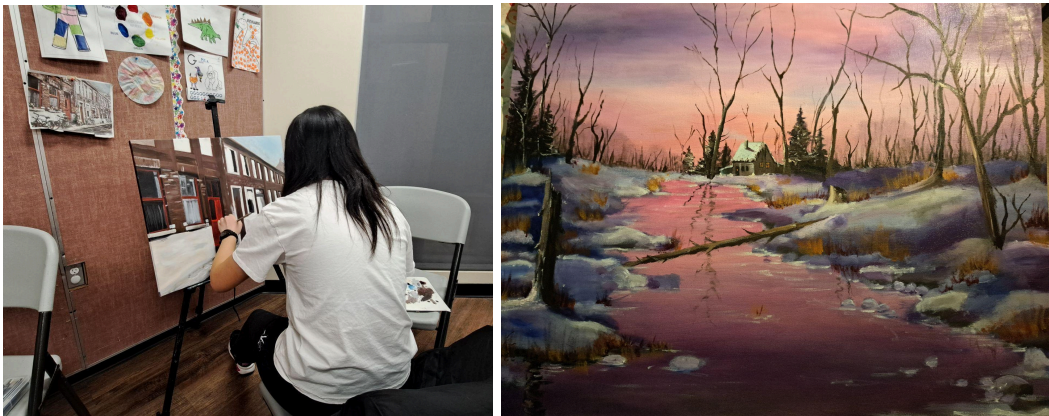
IB CAS PORTFOLIO

Tina Song, kww887

John G. Diefenbaker High School 2023-25

CAS Experience: Creativity

My creative and artistic skills have continually improved during my time in the CAS Program. The Fine Arts specifically have been a big part of my life because it is something that I have always persisted in. I've attended art class at the STC Arts Academy every week for nearly ten years, with my main focus being on oil painting. To work up to this, I did many years of practice in sketching and watercolors, with "homework" assignments to complete every week, including holidays. My teacher also had me practice with painting from memory without looking at the reference photo, and exercises like sketching a black and white version of a reference photo meant for a painting. These have largely led to my growth and success as I continue to refine my skills and develop into the realm of arts.



These are a few pictures of my painting process and a painting I finished recently

In school, I am able to use these skills to make a difference in the community. From my many years of practice, I can confidently use my creative skills in a real life situation. I joined the Bridging the Gap Student Senior's Club in my first two years of high school, and for Christmas, one of the events that was organized was card making for the seniors, and Christmas crafts to do with them. I was easily able to draw images without a reference, but also able to copy them directly from google with surprising accuracy.



This was taken at the senior's center while we were visiting them to do crafts and hand out the Christmas cards we made.

Another activity in which I applied these skills was the annual Ride of the Chiefs event at my school. My group created our own costumes to match the theme we had chosen for the event: Dress to Impress. We especially took time in designing a unique headband for each group member and focused on many details like the font.



CAS Experience: Activity

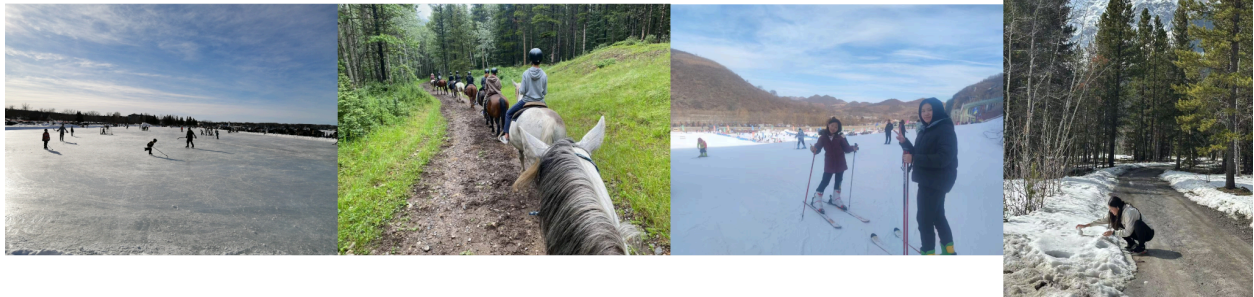
As a child, I was terrified of the water because of the possibility of drowning. I hit a huge roadblock when I redid one level of swimming lessons three times before finally passing it. It wasn't until I joined my high school Swim Team as a blue swimmer in Grade 10, and continued to do it throughout Grade 11 and 12 that I started loving swimming. In Junior High, I had never taken up any athletics in any sort of team or club, but when I heard that Diefenbaker had a swim team, I was immediately drawn to it. I wanted to take up a sport to be more active, and to become a healthier version of myself while having fun. This is what led me to join the swim team in Grade 10, and to continue to do it the rest of my years throughout high school. Swimming alongside the team during practice and competition, I continued to refine my strokes and improve my strength. Through my hard work and dedication, I continue to break my own timed swimming records every year. In every season, for every race, my results have always been an improvement upon an improvement, with my finals times beating my seed times at city championships in all three years. Since my initiation of my swimming experience at the start of my high school career, I have since gained many new skills from the experience. Physically, I have learned to refine my freestyle and correct my breaststroke posture, and learned how to swim the supposed "hardest stroke": butterfly. On another level, I have also learned how to manage the stress from a full IB Diploma student with the 7am practice multiple mornings a week. This has led me to become a much more well rounded person overall.

Results				
(Event 3 Girls 10 Year Olds 25 SC Meter Backstroke)				
	Name	Age Team	Seed Time	Finals Time
74	Song, Tina	10 John G Diefenbaker	27.62	25.24
(Event 5 Girls 10 Year Olds 25 SC Meter Breaststroke)				
	Name	Age Team	Seed Time	Finals Time
90	Song, Tina	10 John G Diefenbaker	44.20	36.61
Event 1 Girls 10 Year Olds 50 SC Meter Freestyle				
	Name	Age Team	Seed Time	Finals Time
45	Song, Tina	10 John G Diefenbaker	50.08	44.87

Here is a link to my recent 50m freestyle race (<https://photos.app.goo.gl/PmJ1nAwARFKwqq5f9>) and an extract from the Swim City Championship results this year. All my finals times are an improvement from my original seed times!

Aside from the swim season, I continue to swim in my daily life, often making the 7k distance to and from the pool by bike. This bike ride followed by a swim and a ride back right after gets my heart rate up faster. The ride there is downhill all the way, but the way back is quite tough.

However, I do feel that after a few times of doing this, my stamina has improved quite a bit and I need to take fewer stops in between to catch my breath.



Though swimming is my favorite, and main source of physical activity, it is often confined to an indoor pool, especially in the winter. Thus, I also spend a lot of my time experiencing the great outdoors throughout the year. This past year, I've re-tried skiing (since elementary school), went horseback riding, skating, and went on walks in many national parks. Horseback riding and skiing were experiences that I had tried when I was younger, so I thought it would be fun to initiate an experience and try them out again. Skating and hiking are activities that are more common in my world. There is an outdoor rink in my neighborhood that I often go to to skate a few rounds at night. This is convenient as it is nice and close and not too busy. When I have more time, I will go on walks all over the place. My favorites are the mountain paths in Kananaskis. The images above are a few snapshots from these experiences.

CAS Experience: Service

Having finished Math 30-1 and Calculus in my Grade 11 year, I show up every Monday morning to tutor others in math at school. However my service projects are not limited to just school events. I have earned the community Service Award and the Canada Cord with Girl Guides, which demonstrates my volunteerism and leadership abilities. I have participated for 8 years, and it is one of the best extracurriculars I have done.

I have also been involved in my community since I was very little. The community association hosts a variety of events including a skate party, yoga, and music in the park. In the summer, there are more events such as compost day, a garage sale parade, a community cleanup, and a community garden to name a few. Nowadays, I'm present at every single event, whether scooping compost into buckets on compost day or handing out and collecting signage for the parade of garage sales. One of my favorite events is the community cleanup because it makes a great difference in society. I help community residents unload their cars and sort the items into donations, recycling, reusables, and garbage. This gives me a sense of accomplishment because I can contribute all I have to offer to the community. Every time an event is finished, I am overcome with immense joy and fulfillment from the rewarding connections I made and the difference I created in society. Ultimately, my time volunteering with the Sandstone Macewan

Community Association has fostered my lasting desire to serve the community. I am grateful to have the opportunity to grow and learn while contributing to the well-being of those around me.

This is a photo of me taken with the truck full of donate-able secondhand items that we took to Value Village after the Community cleanup.

Additionally, I volunteered at the Chinese Academy in my first two years of high school. This year, I have assumed the role of Teaching Assistant of a Kindergarten class at the school. The Chinese Academy gave me the opportunity to work with and lead both preschool-aged children as well as high school students in improving their Chinese by practicing speaking, dictation, and participating in activities regarding the culture.



This photo was taken at the Central Library, where I volunteered for UN Chinese Language Day in collaboration with The Chinese Academy to showcase elements of Chinese culture. Here, I am teaching kids how to tie Chinese knots.



CAS Project: Creativity and Service

Under the high pressure and stressful environments of the International Baccalaureate, mental health as an issue becomes increasingly more prominent. I first realized this when I noticed many people around me struggling to balance their schoolwork with their own lives, which so often resulted in a mental breakdown. For me, one of the things that has allowed me to calm down after experiencing high-stress situations for long periods of time is reading (specifically, fiction books that I can relate to).

My CAS Project is writing book reviews and posting these online for people to read through which allows them to gain insight into the book, but also allows me to summarize the insights I have gained from reading it. We started by making a list of books that fit the theme, and then started writing. My partner and I shared a google doc that we continuously edited to perfect throughout the year. This is both a creative experience and a service experience because through creative writing and careful design, I am able to share with the world my views under the theme and goal of increasing awareness for mental health amongst teens today!

Below is the CAS Project Planning Form that has been used to outline the structure of the project and is evidence of our initial planning stage:

Name of Project owner(s)	Madison Purdy, Tina Song		
Title of Project	Book Reviews for Mental Health		
Collaborator(s) if other than above	N/A		
Culminating product or experience:	Writing book reviews about mental health to raise awareness and underline the importance of having a healthy mind.		
Anticipated Start Date	October 2024	Anticipated Completion Date	June 2024 (and we might continue doing it whenever we have free time in the future)

Brief description of process for completion (CAS Stages):

Investigation	We will research different books that connect to our mental health theme. We will choose a variety of both well known and less popular books, made for all ages and with varying strategies to try.
Preparation	We will read these books within our free time, as well as attempt to use some of the strategies listed in the books. As well, we will take images we feel are appropriate for the books we read in order to build a supply that can be used for our reviews. Finally, we will create both Instagram and GoodReads accounts in order to share our reviews with many.
Action	We will write these reviews on GoodReads, using both strategies and quotes as references to the books. We will include how effective we found the strategies, so that those with similar traits will know what books are a good match for them, and those with opposing traits will be able to eliminate the strategies that work for us, as they likely won't work for them. We will also be taking pictures of these reviews and posting them on our Instagram account in order to further our promotion of mental health.
Demonstration	As stated above, we will be taking pictures of each of our posts, which will allow us to submit them as a part of our reflection and demonstrate our ability to create and reflect on mental health. As well, we will include a final count of followers and likes from both platforms, which will demonstrate how many people we have reached through this project and thus our impact on the community.
Reflection	As a part of our project, we will be reflecting on the strategies within the books. As well, we will do a final reflection on how our mental health has been impacted by these books, as well as strategies we will continue to use later in our lives. We will also record any comments we get from our followers and the like count to reflect on the impact we have on the community.

Throughout the year, I revisited multiple books that I had read before, and spent loads of time in the library digging for new books to read. I spend a lot of my free time reading through these books and later on, writing reviews from them. I quickly found that not only was reading books in my spare time beneficial to my own stress levels, writing the reviews themselves also gave me other things to think about than the heavy load of schoolwork I have to face each week. This CAS Project was aimed at benefiting others, but has helped me more than anything.

This CAS Project isn't something I plan on ending after high school. I believe this is something I could easily commit to throughout the rest of my life. In the future, whenever I have free time, I can turn my love of reading into a positive force for both myself and others through these book reviews!



My Review



Tina
3 reviews

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[Edit my activity](#)

Read

April 8, 2025

All the Bright Places is a fictional story narrated by two characters, Violet Markey and Theodore Finch, who each struggle with mental health issues. Violet, having just lost her older sister in a car accident, struggles with depression, grief, and healing. She counts down the days to graduation with a black marker and refuses to step foot in a car. This symbolizes her inability to reconcile with her past. Finch, on the other hand, deals with extreme depression and suicidal thoughts. He is often doing dangerous things like climbing to the top of the school's bell tower and thinking of jumping. The book goes on to illustrate the ways in which these two characters come together in order to overcome their problems.

I thought it was really interesting that Violet, who intends to live, learns how to from Finch, who intends to die. Violet, who has caring parents and is friends with all the popular kids, has an entirely different situation than Finch whose parents are divorced, and who is regarded as the weird kid in school. Finch has to rely on smoking (un-lit) cigarettes to keep himself in check. The assignment of Finch and Violet as partners for a school project brings them together to explore the world and work out their problems.

Overall, I would recommend this book to anyone looking for a mental health book centered around a fictional story. The book is long and inspiring, but each chapter is short which makes it easy to get through a few in a sitting.

[Edit Review](#)

Here is a finished review that I wrote and posted on Goodreads. This is the culminated product of my CAS Project.

CAS Reflective Statement:

Through the three CAS components, Creativity, Activity, and Service, I have learnt many life lessons that continue to shape my life on a daily basis. My years of high school under the CAS program have shown me the importance of perseverance, resilience, and critical thinking and left a lasting impact on my life. All three aspects of CAS play an integral role in this.

I spent a lot of time dedicated to improving myself through persistence in oil painting which I had been doing for many years prior to high school. I continued to strive for the best when I joined the swim team. I worked my heart out while training, often visiting the pool in the evening to get in some extra pool lengths of training. I managed to show up well ahead of time for every swim practice, showing my perseverance to refine my abilities. Though I didn't end up achieving placement at City Championships, I gained valuable experience from the activity itself.

I also volunteered at The Chinese Academy, where I assisted a variety of different people with learning Chinese. I started off volunteering for a class of tenth graders, in which my main tasks were to help with their pronunciation and sentence structure. Later on, I became a teaching assistant for a class of kindergarteners. This drastic change was initially quite frightening as I felt at a loss for what to do. Being a high schooler myself, I found it easy to connect with the older

kids, and match my assistance to their needs. With the kindergarteners, they needed much more from me. I had to be very patient with them, and hold their hand as they tried to write the simplest Chinese characters. With such a high-demand class, exacerbated by the fact that the class size was quite large, I often came home exhausted and ready to head straight to bed. This experience has taught me to adapt to all the scenarios that life may throw at you, and has trained me to face any challenge I encounter with determination.

The school motto at The Chinese Academy is “立己立人,” which essentially means that “to better others, you must first better yourself.” Through my CAS experiences, I feel that I have demonstrated this motto. I believe that students like us are capable of leaving a lasting positive impact on issues with global significance. CAS has taught me to always strive for excellence, and in doing so, help others achieve the same. It has allowed me to recognize my strengths and weaknesses, to apply my strengths where they can prove useful, and to work hard to improve on my weaknesses.